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TEST 1

READING PASSAGE 1



The development of the London underground railway

In the first half of the 1800s, London's population grew at an **astonishing** rate, and the central area became increasingly **congested**. In addition, the **expansion** of the overground railway network resulted in more and more passengers arriving in the capital. However, in 1846, a Royal Commission decided that the railways should not be allowed to enter the City, the capital's historic and business centre. The result was that the overground railway **stations** formed a **ring** around the City. The area within consisted of poorly built, overcrowded **slums** and the streets were full of **horse-drawn** traffic. Crossing the City became a nightmare. It could take an hour and a half to travel 8 km by horse-drawn **carriage** or bus. **Numerous schemes** were **proposed** to **resolve** these problems, but few succeeded.

railway= a system of tracks that trains travel along
astonishing= surprising, shocking, astounding
congested= overcrowded, crammed, blocked
expansion= extension, growth, enlargement
station= a building and the surrounding area where buses or trains stop for people to get on or off
ring= circle, loop, sphere
slum= a very poor and crowded area, especially of a city
horse-drawn= a horse-drawn vehicle is pulled by a horse.
carriage= a vehicle with four wheels that is usually pulled by horses and was used mainly in the past
numerous= many, plentiful, various
scheme= plan, method, idea
propose= suggest, offer, recommend
resolve= solve, sort out, settle

Amongst the most **vocal advocates** for a solution to London's traffic problems was Charles Pearson, who worked as a **solicitor** for the City of London. He saw both social and economic advantages in building an underground railway that would **link** the overground railway stations together and **clear** London slums at the same time. His idea was to **relocate** the poor workers who lived in the **inner-city** slums to newly **constructed suburbs**, and to provide cheap rail travel for them to get to work. Pearson's ideas gained support amongst some businessmen and in 1851 he **submitted** a plan to **Parliament**. It was **rejected**, but **coincided** with a **proposal** from another group for an underground connecting **line**, which Parliament **passed**.

The two groups **merged** and established the Metropolitan Railway Company in August 1854. The company's plan was to construct an underground railway line from the Great Western Railway's (GWR) station at Paddington to the edge of the City at Farringdon Street - a distance of almost 5 km. The organisation had difficulty in raising the funding for such a **radical** and expensive scheme, not least because of the **critical** articles printed by the **press**. **Objectors** argued that the **tunnels** would **collapse** under the weight of traffic overhead, buildings would be shaken and passengers would be **poisoned** by the **emissions** from the train **engines**. However, Pearson and his partners **persisted**.

The GWR, aware that the new line would finally enable them to run trains into the **heart** of the City, invested almost £250,000 in the scheme. **Eventually**, over a five-year period, £1m was **raised**. The chosen **route** ran beneath existing main roads to minimise the **expense** of **demolishing** buildings. **Originally scheduled** to be completed in 21 months, the construction of the underground line took three years. It was built just below street level using a technique known as 'cut and cover'. A **trench** about ten metres wide and six metres deep was dug, and the **sides temporarily** held up with **timber** beams. Brick walls were then constructed, and finally a brick **arch** was added to create a tunnel. A two-metre-deep layer of soil was laid on top of the tunnel and the road above rebuilt.

The Metropolitan line, which opened on 10 January 1863, was the world's first underground railway. On its first day, almost 40,000 passengers were **carried** between Paddington and Farringdon, the journey taking about 18 minutes. By the end of the Metropolitan's first year of operation, 9.5 million journeys had been made.

vocal= outspoken, loud, forceful
advocate= supporter, promoter, activist
solicitor= a type of lawyer in Britain and Australia
link= connect, join, bring together
clear= tidy up, clear out, empty
relocate= move, displace, change place
inner-city= in the central part of a city where there are often problems because people are poor and there are few jobs and bad houses
construct= build, make, create
suburb= an area on the edge of a large town or city
submit= present, offer, suggest
parliament= the group of people who make the laws for their country
reject= refuse, decline, deny
coincide= happen together, overlap, match
proposal= suggestion, request, offer
line= a railway track
pass= accept, permit, approve

merge= combine, join together, team up
radical= extreme, far-out, progressive
critical= disapproving, fault-finding, unfavorable
press= media, newspapers, journalists
objector= opponent, skeptic, critic
tunnel= a long passage under or through the ground
collapse= breakdown, fall to pieces, fail
poison= harm, infect, injure
emission= exhaust fumes
engine= machine, piece of equipment, mechanism
persist= continue, carry on, stick with

heart= center, core, middle
eventually= finally, in the end, ultimately
raise= to raise money is to succeed in getting it
route= way, road, track
expense= cost, payment, expenditure
demolish= destroy, ruin, wreck
schedule= arrange, plan, organize
originally= firstly, in the beginning, initially
trench= a narrow channel dug into the ground
side= a flat outer surface of an object, especially one that is not the top, the bottom, the front, or the back
temporarily= in the short term, briefly, provisionally
beam= a long, thick piece of wood, metal, or concrete, especially used to support weight in a building or other structure
timber= wood, logs, kindling
arch= a structure, consisting of a curved top on two supports, that holds the weight of something above it

carry= transport, bring, transfer

Even as the Metropolitan began operation, the first **extensions** to the line were being **authorised**; these were built over the next five years, reaching Moorgate in the east of London and Hammersmith in the west. The original plan was to pull the trains with **steam locomotives**, using **firebricks** in the **boilers** to provide steam, but these engines were never **introduced**. Instead, the line used specially designed locomotives that were fitted with **water tanks** in which steam could be **condensed**. However, smoke and **fumes** remained a problem, even though **ventilation shafts** were added to the tunnels.

Despite the extension of the underground railway, by the 1880s, **congestion** on London's streets had become worse. The problem was partly that the existing underground lines formed a **circuit** around the centre of London and extended to the suburbs, but did not cross the capital's centre. The 'cut and cover' method of construction was not an option in this part of the capital. The only **alternative** was to **tunnel** deep underground.

Although the technology to create these tunnels existed, steam locomotives could not be used in such a **confined** space. It wasn't until the development of a **reliable** electric **motor**, and a **means** of transferring power from the **generator** to a moving train, that the world's first deep-level electric railway, the City & South London, became possible. The line opened in 1890, and ran from the City to Stockwell, south of the River Thames. The trains were made up of three **carriages** and driven by electric engines. The carriages were narrow and had tiny windows just below the roof because it was thought that passengers would not want to look out at the tunnel walls. The line was not without its problems, mainly caused by an unreliable power supply. Although the City & South London Railway was a great **technical** achievement, it did not make a profit. Then, in 1900, the Central London Railway, known as the 'Tuppenny Tube', began operation using new electric locomotives. It was very popular and soon afterwards new railways and extensions were added to the growing **tube** network. By 1907, the heart of today's Underground system was **in place**.

extension= lengthening, expansion, increase
authorise= approve, permit, give permission
steam locomotive= a vehicle with an engine powered by steam, used for pulling trains
firebrick= a type of brick that is not damaged by high temperatures
boiler= a device that heats water
introduce= begin, launch, start
water tank= a large container for collecting and storing water
condense= to change or make something change from a gas to a liquid or solid state
fume= gas, smog, emission
ventilation= air circulation, freshening, airing
shaft= a long passage through a building or through the ground

congestion= overcrowding, jamming, blocking
circuit= route, path, track
alternative= another possibility, substitute, replacement
tunnel= dig, excavate, burrow

confined= small, cramped, enclosed
reliable= trustworthy, dependable, unfailing
motor= a device that changes electricity or fuel into movement and makes a machine work
means= way, method, measure
generator= power producer
carriage= any of the separate parts of a train in which the passengers sit
technical= mechanical, industrial, scientific
tube= London's underground train system
in place= ready, ripe, primed

TEST 1

READING PASSAGE 2



A. Stadiums are among the oldest forms of urban **architecture**:

vast stadiums where the public could watch sporting events were at the centre of western city life as far back as the ancient Greek and Roman **Empires**, well before the **construction** of the great **medieval cathedrals** and the **grand** 19th- and 20th-century railway **stations** which **dominated** urban **skylines** in later eras.

Today, however, stadiums are **regarded** with growing **scepticism**. Construction costs can **soar** above £1 billion, and stadiums finished for **major** events such as the Olympic Games or the FIFA World Cup have **notably fallen into** disuse and disrepair.

architecture= design, building, style
vast= huge, enormous, massive
empire= a group of countries ruled by a single person, government, or country
construction= building, creation, development
medieval= of or from the middle ages (= the period in the past from about 500 to 1500)
cathedral= a very large, usually stone, building for christian worship
grand= large, huge, massive
station= depot, terminal, stop
dominate= to be the largest or most noticeable part of something
skyline= the shape of objects against the sky, esp. buildings in a city
regard= think, consider, deem
scepticism= disbelief, doubt, uncertainty
soar= rise, escalate, rocket
major= most important, main, key
notably= especially, particularly, remarkably
fall into= to gradually get into a particular condition, especially to get into a bad condition

But this need not be **the case**. History shows that stadiums can **drive** urban development and **adapt** to the culture of every **age**. Even today, **architects** and planners are finding new ways to adapt the **mono-functional** sports **arenas** which became **emblematic** of modernisation during the 20th century.

The amphitheatre* of Aries in southwest France, with a **capacity** of 25,000 **spectators**, is perhaps the best example of just how **versatile** stadiums can be. Built by the Romans in 90 AD, it became a **fortress** with four towers after the fifth century, and was then transformed into a village containing more than 200 houses. With the growing **interest** in **conservation** during the 19th century, it was **converted** back into an arena for the **staging** of bullfights, **thereby** returning the structure to its original use as a **venue** for public **spectacles**.

Another example is the **imposing** arena of Verona in northern Italy, with space for 30,000 spectators, which was built 60 years before the Aries amphitheatre and 40 years before Rome's famous Colosseum. It has **endured** the centuries and is currently considered one of the world's **prime** sites for opera, thanks to its **outstanding acoustics**.

The area in the centre of the Italian town of Lucca, known as the Piazza dell'Anfiteatro, is yet another impressive example of an amphitheatre becoming **absorbed** into **the fabric of** the city. The site **evolved** in a similar way to Aries and was **progressively** filled with buildings from the Middle Ages until the 19th century, variously used as houses, a salt **depot** and a prison. But rather than reverting to an arena, it became a market square, designed by Romanticist architect Lorenzo Nottolini. Today, the **ruins** of the amphitheatre remain **embedded** in the various shops and **residences** surrounding the public square.

There are many similarities between modern stadiums and the ancient amphitheatres **intended** for games. But some of the flexibility was lost at the beginning of the 20th century, as stadiums were developed using new products such as steel and **reinforced concrete**, and **made use of** bright lights for night-time matches.

Many such stadiums are situated in suburban areas, designed for sporting use only and surrounded by parking lots. These factors mean that they may not be as **accessible** to the **general public**, require more energy to run and contribute to urban heat.

(not) **the case**= (not) true
drive= push, force, propel
adapt= fit, modify, adjust
age= period, time, era
architect= designer, engineer, builder
mono-functional= having a single function
arena= sports ground, stadium, pitch
emblematic= symbolic, representative, characteristic

capacity= volume, size, space
spectator= viewer, watcher, observer
versatile= flexible, adaptable, multipurpose
fortress= a large, strong building or group of buildings that can be defended from attack
interest= concern, attention, notice
conservation= protection, preservation, maintenance
convert= change, switch, alter
staging= performance, presentation, production
thereby= so, thus, in that way
venue= site, location, setting
spectacle= event, performance, display

imposing= impressive, striking, magnificent
endure= last, survive, persist
prime= excellent, first-rate, top-notch
outstanding= wonderful, excellent, exceptional
acoustic= sound, audio, auditory

absorb= incorporate, merge, integrate
the fabric of= the structure or parts of something
evolve= grow, progress, develop
progressively= gradually, little by little, with time
depot= storehouse, warehouse, storage area
ruin= debris, wreckage, remains
embed= incorporate, lodge, fix
residence= a home

intend= designate, aim, plan
reinforced concrete= concrete that contains metal rods to make it stronger
make use of= use, utilize, exploit

accessible= available, nearby, easy to get to
general public= population, citizens, ordinary people

But many of today's most **innovative** architects see **scope** for the stadium to help improve the city. Among the current strategies, two seem to be having **particular** success: the stadium as an urban **hub**, and as a **power plant**.

There's a growing trend for stadiums to be **equipped** with public spaces and services that serve a function beyond sport, such as hotels, **retail outlets**, **conference** centres, restaurants and bars, children's playgrounds and green space. Creating mixed-use developments such as this **reinforces compactness** and multi-functionality, making more efficient use of land and helping to **regenerate** urban spaces.

This **opens** the space **up to** families and a wider **cross-section** of society, instead of **catering** only to **sportspeople** and **supporters**. There have been many examples of this in the UK: the mixed-use facilities at Wembley and Old Trafford have become a **blueprint** for many other stadiums in the world.

The phenomenon of stadiums as power stations has **arisen from** the idea that energy problems can be overcome by **integrating interconnected** buildings **by means of** a smart **grid**, which is an electricity supply network that uses digital communications technology to **detect** and react to local changes in **usage**, without **significant** energy losses. Stadiums are ideal for these purposes, because their **canopies** have a large surface area for fitting **photovoltaic panels** and rise high enough (more than 40 metres) to make use of **micro** wind **turbines**.

Freiburg Mage Solar Stadium in Germany is the first of a new **wave** of stadiums as power plants, which also includes the Amsterdam Arena and the Kaohsiung Stadium. The latter, **inaugurated** in 2009, has 8,844 photovoltaic panels producing up to 1.14 GWh of electricity annually. This reduces the annual output of carbon dioxide by 660 tons and supplies up to 80 percent of the surrounding area when the stadium is not **in use**. This is **proof** that a stadium can serve its city, and have a **decidedly** positive impact in terms of reduction of CO₂ emissions.

Sporting arenas have always been **central** to the life and culture of cities. In every **era**, the stadium has **acquired** new value and uses: from **military** fortress to **residential** village, public space to theatre and most recently a **field** for **experimentation** in **advanced** engineering. The stadium of today now **brings together** multiple functions, thus helping cities to create a **sustainable** future.

* amphitheatre: (especially in Greek and Roman architecture) an open circular or oval building with a central space surrounded by tiers of seats for spectators, for the presentation of dramatic or sporting events

innovative= modern, novel, groundbreaking
scope= opportunity, possibility, chance
particular= specific, exact, certain
hub= the central or main part of something where there is most activity
power plant= a factory where electricity is produced

equip= provide, give, furnish
retail outlet= a store that sells goods to the public
conference= meeting, seminar, discussion
reinforce= strengthen, bolster, support
compactness= neatness, smallness, trimness
regenerate= renew, redevelop, restart

open sth up to= to make something available
cross-section= representation, sample
cater= serve, provide for, accommodate
sportspeople= athlete, sports player
supporter= fan, follower, enthusiast
blueprint= prototype, example

arise from= stem from, result from, develop out of
integrate= mix, add, combine
interconnected= connected, joined, interrelated
by means of= by, via, using
grid= network, net, web
detect= discover, notice, identify
usage= the way something is treated or used
significant= large, big, sizable
canopy= top, covering, roof
photovoltaic= able to produce electricity from light
panel= board, pane, sheet
micro= very small
turbine= a type of machine through which liquid or gas flows and turns a special wheel with blades in order to produce power

wave= trend, tendency, movement
inaugurate= install, launch, initiate
in use= working, in operation, active
proof= evidence, confirmation, facts
decidedly= definitely, obviously, undoubtedly

central= vital, essential, key
era= period, time, age
acquire= get, obtain, gain
military= armed, soldierly, fighting
residential= housing, inhabited, populated
field= ground, arena, pitch
experimentation= research, testing, investigation
advanced= developed, superior, sophisticated
bring together= combine, mix, gather
sustainable= maintainable, supportable, defensible

TEST 1

READING PASSAGE 3



Aнна Кея reviews Charles Spencer's book about the **hunt** for King Charles II during the English Civil War of the seventeenth century

Charles Spencer's latest book, *To Catch a King*, tells us the story of the hunt for King Charles II in the six weeks after his **resounding defeat** at the Battle of Worcester in September 1651. And what a story it is. After his father was **executed** by the **Parliamentarians** in 1649, the young Charles II **sacrificed** one of the very **principles** his father had died for and did a **deal** with the Scots, **thereby** accepting Presbyterianism* as the national religion

in return for being **crowned** King of Scots. His arrival in Edinburgh **prompted** the English Parliamentary **army** to **invade** Scotland in a **pre-emptive strike**. This was followed by a Scottish invasion of England. The two sides finally faced one another at Worcester in

hunt= pursuit, search, chase

resounding= very great

defeat= loss, setback, reverse # victory

execute= to kill someone as a legal punishment

Parliamentarian= a supporter of Parliament in the English Civil War; a Roundhead

sacrifice= give up, let go, lose

principle= value, standard, norm

deal= agreement, arrangement, transaction

thereby= so, thus, in that way

in return for= as an exchange for something

crown= to make someone officially a king or queen of a country

prompt= encourage, stimulate, provoke

army= military, defense force, soldiers

invade= attack, conquer, occupy

pre-emptive strike= a surprise attack that is launched in order to prevent the enemy from doing it to you

the west of England in 1651. After being **comprehensively** defeated on the **meadows** outside the city by the Parliamentary army, the 21-year-old king found himself the subject of a national manhunt, with a huge **sum** offered for his **capture**. Over the following six weeks he managed, through a series of heart-poundingly close **escapes**, to **evade** the Parliamentarians before seeking **refuge** in France. For the next nine years, the **penniless** and defeated Charles **wandered** around Europe with only a small group of loyal supporters.

Years later, after his **restoration** as king, the 50-year-old Charles II **requested** a meeting with the writer and **diarist** Samuel Pepys. His intention when asking Pepys to **commit his story to paper** was to ensure that this most extraordinary **episode** was never forgotten. Over two three-hour **sittings**, the king **related to** him in great detail his personal **recollections** of the six weeks he had spent as a **fugitive**. As the king and secretary **settled down** (a scene that is surely a gift for a future **scriptwriter**), Charles **commenced** his story: 'After the battle was so absolutely lost as to be beyond hope of recovery, I began to think of the best way of saving myself.

One of the joys of Spencer's book, a result not least of its use of Charles II's own **narrative** as well as those of his supporters, is just how close the reader gets to the action. The day-by-day retelling of the fugitives' **doings** provides **delicious** details: the cutting of the king's long hair with agricultural shears, the use of walnut leaves to **dye** his pale skin, and the day Charles spent lying on a branch of the great oak tree in Boscobel Wood as the Parliamentary soldiers **scoured** the forest floor below. Spencer **draws out** both the humour - such as the **preposterous** refusal of Charles's friend Henry Wilmot to adopt **disguise** on the grounds that it was **beneath his dignity** - and the emotional **tension** when the secret of the king's presence was **cautiously** revealed to his supporters.

Charles's adventures after losing the Battle of Worcester hide the uncomfortable truth that **whilst** almost everyone in England had been **appalled** by the **execution** of his father, they had not welcomed the arrival of his son with the Scots army, but had instead firmly **bolted** their doors. This was partly because he rode at the **head** of what looked like a foreign invasion force and partly because, after almost a decade of **civil war**, people were **desperate** to avoid it beginning again. This makes it all the more interesting that Charles II himself loved the story so much ever after. As well as retelling it to anyone who would listen, causing eye rolling among **courtiers**, he **set in train** a series of **initiatives** to **memorialise** it. There was to be a new order of **chivalry**, the Knights of the Royal Oak. A series of enormous oil paintings **depicting** the episode were produced, including a two-metre-wide **canvas** of Boscobel Wood and a set of six similarly enormous paintings of the king **on the run**. In 1660, Charles II **commissioned** the artist John Michael Wright to paint a flying **squadron** of cherubs* carrying an oak tree to the heavens on the

comprehensively= completely, totally
meadow= field, grazing land, pasture
sum= an amount of money
capture= arrest, seizure, imprisonment
escape= running away, getaway, breakout
evade= avoid, stay away from, steer clear
refuge= place of safety, protection, sanctuary
penniless= poor, impoverished, broke
wander= walk, stroll, roam

restoration= return, re-establishment, reinstatement
request= ask for, demand, invite
diarist= writer, biographer, journalist
commit sth to paper= to write something down
episode= event, incident, affair
sitting= meeting, session, appointment
relate= tell, speak about, narrate
recollection= memory, recall, reminiscence
fugitive= a person who is running away or hiding from the police or a dangerous situation
settle down= relax, calm down, slow down
scriptwriter= someone who writes stories for movies, television programs, etc
commence= begin, start, originate

narrative= description, story, tale
doings= someone's activities
delicious= enjoyable, pleasant, appealing
dye= change the color of, tint, color
scour= to search a place or thing very carefully in order to try to find something
draw out= lengthen, make last, prolong
preposterous= silly, laughable, ridiculous
disguise= mask, camouflage, concealment
beneath your dignity= If something is beneath your dignity, you feel that you are too important to do it
tension= pressure, tightness, stiffness
cautiously= with care, carefully, watchfully

whilst= while, whereas, although
appalled= shocked, horrified, disgusted
execution= the death sentence, killing, putting to death
bolt= fasten, lock, secure
head= top, peak, summit
civil war= a war fought by different groups of people living in the same country
desperate= determined, eager, in urgent need
courtier= a companion of a queen, king, or other ruler in their official home
set in train= to start a process
initiative= plan, scheme, programme
memorialise= honor, celebrate, remember
chivalry= the system of behaviour followed by knights in the medieval period
depict= portray, illustrate, represent
canvas= strong, rough cloth used for painting
on the run= running, fleeing, escaping
commission= order, assign, appoint
squadron= a military force consisting of a group of aircraft or ships

ceiling of his **bedchamber**. It is hard to imagine many other kings marking the lowest point in their life so enthusiastically, or indeed **pulling off** such an escape in the first place.

Charles Spencer is the perfect person to **pass the story on** to a new generation. His **pacey**, readable **prose steers deftly clear of** modern idioms and elegantly brings to life the details of the great tale. He has **even-handed** sympathy for both the **fugitive** king and the **fierce** republican **regime** that hunted him, and he succeeds in his desire to explore far more of the background of the story than previous books on the subject have done. Indeed, the opening third of the book is about how Charles II found himself at Worcester in the first place, which for some will be reason alone to read *To Catch a King*.

The **tantalising** question left, in the end, is that of what it all meant. Would Charles II have been a different king had these six weeks never happened? The days and nights spent in hiding must have affected him in some way. Did the need to **assume** disguises, to survive on wit and charm alone, to use **trickery** and **subterfuge** to escape from tight corners help form him? This is the one area where the book doesn't quite hit the **mark**. Instead its depiction of Charles II in his final years as an ineffective, pleasure-loving **monarch** doesn't **do justice to** the man (neither is it accurate), or to the complexity of his character. But this one **niggle** aside, *To Catch a King* is an excellent **read**, and those who come to it knowing little of the famous tale will find they have a **treat** in store.

•Presbyterianism: part of the reformed Protestant religion
•Cherub: an image of angelic children used in paintings

bedchamber= a bedroom
pull off= to succeed in doing something difficult or unexpected:

pass sth on= hand sth down, retell, continue
pacey= fast-paced, action-packed
prose= writing style, text, style
steers clear of= avoid, omit, reject
deftly= skillfully, cleverly, smartly
even-handed= fair, balanced, impartial
fugitive= escapee, runaway, absconder
fierce= violent, aggressive, brutal
regime= government, administration, management

tantalising= exciting, alluring, provoking
assume= use, adopt. acquire
trickery= dishonesty, fraud, deception
subterfuge= trick, deception, artifice
mark= an intended result or an object aimed at
monarch= ruler, king, queen
do justice to sb/sth= to treat someone or something in a way that is fair and shows their or its true qualities
niggle= doubt, worry, concern
read= the act of reading something
treat= delight, fun, pleasure